



Arch Linux

The Ideal Geek Distro?

Inspired by CRUX and started in March 2002 by Judd Vinet, the Arch Linux project might have been a late entrant into the world of distros. But within a short span of time, it has gained lots of fans, users and contributors. Arch Linux, according to its website, is a minimalist distribution aimed at intermediate Linux users who are not afraid of the command line.

Arch sticks firmly to the CRUX philosophy, 'Keep it Simple'. 'Simplicity', according to Arch, is defined as "...without unnecessary additions, modifications or complications." Arch is so simple that the core image is less than 320 MB. It's optimised for i686 processors, which means you need CPUs of Pentium II or a higher class to run. Arch also has an official x86_64 version.

An install of the latest Arch Linux core image will give you a command-line interface—no X, no desktop environment, no extra software. It might sound stupid—why would you want only a command line interface? But that is what I love about Arch. Linux is all about choice and in the process of trying to keep everything ready for you when the installation is over, distros like Ubuntu, openSUSE, Mandriva and the like, do not give users much of a choice as to what software they need to have. Of course, such distros are fantastic when it comes to first-time Linux users. They serve as a launch pad for them to better understand Linux. But intermediate Linux users would rarely use them (unless they are developing or contributing). [ED: And if you're also one of those who likes to get started with things without much fuss ;-)]

The question that now arises is -- in what

way is it better than other proven distros like Debian, Slackware, etc?

Let us not try and compare distros. Every distro has its own philosophy. Here's what I like about Arch:

1. **Minimalist:** You can install it easily on computers that are relatively old. I've personally installed it on a Pentium III desktop with 128 MB of RAM and it works really well. Also, I'm typing this out on my laptop, which has a Core 2 Duo processor and 3 GB of RAM.
2. **Rolling release:** A rolling-release system is basically a framework in which you get the latest version of the operating system if you have the latest updates installed. It eliminates the headaches that I used to get using '*dist-upgrade*' on Debian. Yes, Gentoo, Sidux and Debian Sid also have a rolling release system. But I feel they are either too hard to install (Gentoo) or rather unpredictable with respect to stability (Sid).
3. **Configurability:** Since Arch core installs only a command line system with the necessary packages to detect a network, keyboard, display and other vital hardware, you can configure the system, pick and choose the software you need and set it up in just the way